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REWIRING THE STATE

BUILDING INSTITUTIONS FOR A MULTIPOLAR AGE

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"Institutions make or break nations." In a world increasingly defined by polycentric power, disruptive technology, and post-pandemic uncertainty, this statement is more than a platitude – it is a warning. Across the Global South, the modern state faces a paradox. It wields vast symbolic power, yet remains paralysed by outdated bureaucratic machinery, fragmented governance ecosystems, and increasingly restive citizenries. If emerging powers are to stake their claim in the multipolar world order, institutional reform is not optional – it is existential.

The case for urgent reform

Post-pandemic governance fatigue has exposed a critical vulnerability: many state institutions were designed for a different era, and their rigidity has become an obstacle to resilience. From public health delivery to energy regulation, from service delivery to disaster preparedness, the post-2020 world has made it clear that agility, coherence, and accountability are no longer aspirational ideals – they are prerequisites for legitimacy.

This urgency is especially pronounced in the Global South, where institutions are grappling with compounded crises: climate change, digital transition, rising debt burdens, and geopolitical polarisation. States must now navigate a landscape in which supply chains are weaponised, big data shapes voter sentiment, and environmental risks undermine national sovereignty. Yet too many institutions – built on colonial or donor-era models – lack the architecture, resources, and mandate to operate effectively in this context.

South Africa's ongoing efforts at public sector digitalisation provide one instructive example. While frameworks exist for e-governance and smart systems, the lack of coordinated digital infrastructure and capacity-building has undermined implementation. India's "Minimum Government, Maximum Governance" initiative signals a similar attempt to reconfigure the state's presence – less as an intrusive bureaucracy and more as a platform for coordinated policy action. Both models, despite challenges, reflect a growing recognition that institutional reinvention is now imperative.

Legacy systems vs future demands

The heart of the challenge lies in the mismatch between 20th-century governance models and 21st-century complexity. Legacy bureaucracies are structured for vertical, rule-bound operations – unsuited to the networked, fast-moving demands of the digital age. Artificial intelligence, decentralised finance, cybersecurity, and transnational regulatory challenges require institutions that can anticipate change, coordinate horizontally, and learn in real time.

Yet reforms are consistently met with resistance. In Kenya, for example, attempts to overhaul public procurement systems have faced institutional inertia, elite capture, and political sabotage – despite the introduction of digital platforms to curb corruption. In Nigeria, the bureaucratic reform agenda, although ambitious, is often stalled by a lack of inter-agency coherence and fragmented accountability mechanisms. The lesson is clear: without political will and citizen engagement, reform remains surface-deep.